



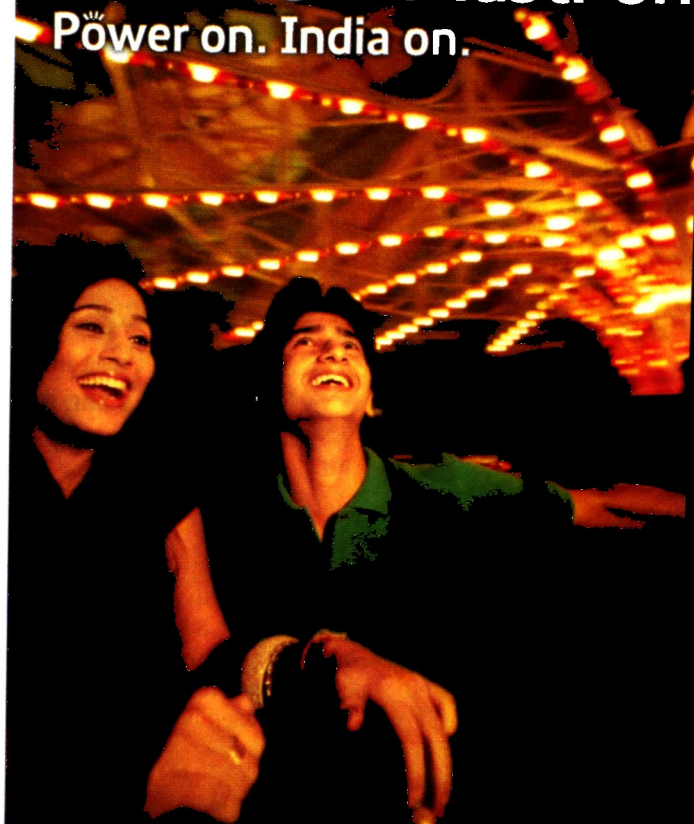
**POLL CAPERS: The Lingayat community stands firm with Yeddyurappa (above); Congress wants Krishna (L) to hit the poll path; Gowda (extreme left) can never be written off**

Governor S.M. Krishna to hit the poll path to counter Deve Gowda's might. Singh and Krishna are strong regional satraps. They are among the leaders who have called on the state party unit to stave off any attempts by others to poach the traditional votebanks of the party which consist of the backward classes and the minorities.

Right now, the Congress is in a tricky situation. There are a number of leaders but not enough soldiers to toil at the grassroots level, unlike BJP which has the strong support of the RSS cadre and its own soldiers who are used to listening to their immediate bosses in the regions.

The party will have to work hard to up its tally from 65 seats it had won last time. Even BJP will have to put its nose to the grindstone to push up its numbers from last time's 79. JD(S) had won 58 seats in the last election. To reach the magic figure of 113, the parties have to ensure that the verdict is not fractured again, which though considering the goings-on in the state is a big possibility. And in such a scenario, Mayawati and Co. may just have a key role to play after all. ■

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